

Chapter 128_2 - Growing Feelings

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The bamboo house was half destroyed, but fortunately the framework remained intact and only needed repairs. Ning Fuyi was too lazy to build another dwelling, so she proposed to help Chu Qingqiu repair the bamboo house, with the condition that she would stay and live together.

Chu Qingqiu naturally refused, but that very night the person squeezed into her room, spread a grass mat on the ground, and fell into deep sleep. No matter how angry Chu Qingqiu became, it was to no avail.

From then on, whenever there were thunder punishments, Ning Fuyi would always help her. Over time, Chu Qingqiu even became accustomed to being embraced around the waist during painful moments and carried away from the heavenly thunder's pursuit.

Even though her heart was hard as iron, she gradually developed an imperceptible dependence—a mutual reliance as if their lives were bound together.

There were no seasons in the chaos, time seemed frozen in spring when a hundred flowers bloomed. The cycle of day and night was extremely long, black and white connecting, making sunrise and sunset rare beautiful sights.

On this day, Ning Fuyi woke from her sleep to find the bed beside her empty and cold to the touch, indicating the person had been gone for a long time. She turned over, sat up, and walked outside.

Outside, the sky was vast and boundless, stretching for thousands of li, with rich and colorful sunset clouds filling the horizon, dyeing the distant mountain peaks golden.

On the nearby slope stood a figure facing the sunset light, silhouette gentle, hair floating, with starlight filtering through the gaps. Beside her stood an old tree with rustling leaves, so lonely that even Han Ya¹ couldn't perch on it.

That white jade flute that once claimed lives was now used as a musical instrument, with trickling flute sounds flowing desolately.

Ning Fuyi's breathing quickened slightly as she walked toward her.

"The Divine Venerable is in such fine spirits," she said.

The flute sound stopped abruptly. The person lowered her hand without speaking.

After a long while, she suddenly said: "Yesterday I heard you talking in your sleep—you seemed to be crying, muttering some names. I also saw your demonic energy overflow because of this, being devoured and consuming your mind."

Ning Fuyi's heart tightened for a moment, then she smiled wryly: "Just departed friends. I am already a demon—even if completely devoured, what does it matter?"

"Those without humanity—how can the word 'demon' even encompass that?" Chu Qingqiu frowned. "When the time comes to overturn the six realms² and destroy countless families, is that what you want?"

"I can't think that far ahead. I only want those who humiliated me to die without burial ground," Ning Fuyi said mockingly.

"If those you care about die because of you, could you still say such foolish words?" Chu Qingqiu turned around, her face falling into shadow.

When she turned, her peach blossom eyes became more vivid with anger. Ning Fuyi's heart skipped a beat, her gaze shifting as she looked away.

"Those I care about?" She suddenly let out several cold, melodious laughs, the sound graceful yet bone-chillingly cold.

"Do you want to hear what I've experienced these years, Divine Venerable Chu Ling?" she said.

Night came quickly. The last ray of sunset light disappeared under the clouds, and the night of Primordial Chaos had no stars—everywhere was heavy darkness.

Chu Qingqiu leaned against the branches of the old tree, a breeze lifting her skirt hem. The cold air brought her back to her senses as she looked sideways toward the bamboo house.

Her usually calm and waveless eyes showed confusion again. In her long, monotonous life, righteousness and evil had always been opposed and distinct. She had always been able to distinguish right from wrong and do the right thing.

If there was anything that broke the norm, it was her inability to bear Ning Changfeng's pleading, so she spared Ning Fuyi and concealed the fate that awaited her.

She prided herself on being impartial and had never acknowledged friendship with anyone. But when the usually proud Ning Changfeng knelt before her, she felt a pang of sorrow, and her eyes, which never shed tears, welled up with warmth.

That warmth ultimately didn't flow down, but her heart still softened. From then on, that was the first time she broke the way she had faithfully kept for ten million years.

She sat in a daze for a moment, then finally slid down to the ground, stepping on the moist grass leaves as she walked back to the bamboo house. When the door opened, familiar sounds of crying echoed in her ears.

This time Chu Qingqiu felt no impatience. She slowly walked to the bedside, looking down in the faint heavenly light at the young woman curled up on the ground, trembling all over from crying.

No matter how fierce and unruly she was during the day, when crying she looked like that child with short arms and legs who had been locked outside and cried all night.

Tears nearly flooded the grass mat beneath her. Chu Qingqiu lifted her sleeves and stepped forward, but hesitated and stopped.

Finally, she lifted her horizontally and walked to the bedside, laying her flat on the bed. The woman quickly curled up again, biting her wrist in the dream while silently shedding tears.

Dark energy faintly swirled around her, making the nightmare deeper.

Chu Qingqiu waved her hand to dispel the dark energy. For the first time, she doubted—was she really wrong?

Ning Fuyi cried all night. When she woke, it was still night. Her tears had dried, leaving only dampness on the pillow. She reached out to touch it and slowly sat up.

Her elbow accidentally hit the bed post, making her red lips tremble. Only then did she realize she wasn't sleeping on the ground but on a warm bed, while the woman who was cold and clear as a divine flower was now lying flat on the ground.

"Among the crowd, one beautiful glance turns all worldly colors to dust³." This was the poem that Ning Fuyi, when she was older and didn't hate Chu Qingqiu so much, would always think of upon seeing her.

Today was no exception. She knelt looking at the woman's sleeping face for a long time before silently getting down, reaching over the woman's shoulders and knees to slowly lift her and place her back on the bed.

The two of them had been dependent on each other for so long that such contact had become habitual. They both regarded it as nothing unusual between elder and younger, or even between enemies.

Chu Qingqiu didn't want to face her, so she pretended to remain asleep.

Who would have thought that before leaving, Ning Fuyi glanced at her hand and saw that black bead, noticing she had never removed it. Suddenly curious, she reached out to touch it.

The Mind Bead⁴ was extremely precious to Chu Qingqiu. She was immediately startled and instinctively struck back at Ning Fuyi. Accidentally pulling too hard on her sleeve, Ning Fuyi suddenly toppled over. Though she managed to stop in time, her mouth still brushed past Chu Qingqiu's cherry lips.

In that instant, both froze.

Ning Fuyi was the first to react, pretending nothing happened as she got up and quickly walked out the threshold.

Chu Qingqiu opened her eyes in the darkness. After a long while, she reached up to wipe the moisture from her lips and tightly closed her eyes.

The fifth thunder strike Ning Fuyi faced after entering the chaos was finally not as smooth as the previous ones. The thunderclaps were violent and dense. She dodged while holding Chu Qingqiu for a full half day, but finally couldn't escape and was struck in the waist by a muffled thunder, immediately rolling down to the bottom of the mountain.

But she didn't know why—even though the heavenly thunder had penetrated her entire being, after falling off the cliff, she still instinctively held the person tightly beneath her.

Countless rocks and debris rumbled into the riverbed. When the two regained consciousness, the dark clouds had dispersed again, leaving the mountains and rivers scarred.

Chu Qingqiu emerged from those soft arms and used white bone to sweep away the rubble pressing on her. Her movements showed panic as she disheveled, pulling the person whose back was beaten bloody to the shore, desperately scattering feather-like immortal power.

The cool sensation penetrated the wounds. Only then did Ning Fuyi wake from the dizziness of being struck by lightning. She slightly parted her lips, spitting out blood from her mouth, and immediately saw Chu Qingqiu with her tense expression, busily working.

"Don't overthink it. I didn't insist on protecting you—the heavenly thunder came too fast, and I didn't have time to let go," she explained.

Chu Qingqiu's hands continued their busy work, but something was wrong.

Ning Fuyi noticed the wrongness and lowered her head to brush away her hair, frowning: "Why are your eyes red?"

Footnotes:

¹ **Han Ya (寒鸦)** - Cold crows, a type of bird mentioned in classical Chinese poetry, often symbolizing loneliness or desolation

² **Six Realms (六界)** - The six domains of existence in Chinese Buddhist and cultivation cosmology: Heaven, Asura, Human, Animal, Hungry Ghost, and Hell realms

³ **Among the crowd, one beautiful glance...** - A reference to classical Chinese poetry describing someone so beautiful that their single glance makes all other worldly colors seem dull in comparison

⁴ **Mind Bead (一念珠)** - A cultivation artifact that likely stores memories, thoughts, or spiritual essence—extremely precious and personal